

Shell voicings: Major ii-V-I all keys



Julian Bradley
JazzTutorial.com

**Your challenge: To play the ii-V-I through all 12 keys,
note-perfectly, three times in a row.
If you mess up - start again!**

Difficulty level = Medium

PIANO

4/4

Dm⁷ G⁷ Cmaj⁷ → Cm⁷ F⁷ Bbmaj⁷ →

Position A Position B Position A

Play both hands up or down an octave as needed

Bbm⁷ Eb⁷ Abmaj⁷ → Abm⁷ Db⁷ Gbmaj⁷ →

F#m⁷ B⁷ Emaj⁷ → Em⁷ A⁷ Dmaj⁷ →

Dm⁷ G⁷ Cmaj⁷ (That's the first six keys) **C#m⁷ F#⁷ Bmaj⁷** ➔

Up a half-step

Bm⁷ E⁷ Amaj⁷ ➔ **Am⁷ D⁷ Gmaj⁷** ➔

Gm⁷ C⁷ Fmaj⁷ ➔ **Fm⁷ Bb⁷ Ebmaj⁷** ➔

Eb^{m7} Ab⁷ Dbmaj⁷ ➔ **C#m⁷ F#⁷ Bmaj⁷**

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Now do the same but switch positions. This time play
position B - A - B

Difficulty level = Medium

Chord progression: Dm^7 G^7 $Cmaj^7 \rightarrow Cm^7$ F^7 $Bbmaj^7 \rightarrow$

Position B Position A Position B

Play both hands up or down an octave as needed

Chord progression: Bbm^7 Eb^7 $Abmaj^7 \rightarrow Abm^7$ Db^7 $Gbmaj^7 \rightarrow$

Chord progression: $F\#m^7$ B^7 $E:maj^7 \rightarrow Em^7$ A^7 $D:maj^7 \rightarrow$

Chord progression: Dm^7 G^7 $Cmaj^7$ $C\#m^7$ $F\#^7$ $gmaj^7 \rightarrow$
(That's the first six keys)

Up a half-step

Bm⁷ E⁷ Amaj⁷ → Am⁷ D⁷ Gmaj⁷ →
 Gm⁷ C⁷ Fmaj⁷ → Fm⁷ Bb⁷ Ebmaj⁷ →
 Ebm⁷ Ab⁷ Dbmaj⁷ → C#m⁷ F#⁷ Bmaj⁷

That's all 12 keys!

"Why is this important?"

Shell voicings are the simplest type of voicing you can play (i.e. fewest notes). They contrast nicely next to the more sophisticated chord voicings that have 5, 6, or 7 notes. By playing shells, you create variety in your arrangements.

"When to use shells?"

Shells are ideal when the melody note is the 3rd (play position B = 1 / 7 3).

Or when the melody note is the 7th (play position A = 1 / 3 7)

If you want to play shell voicings, you must master the ii-V-I through all 12 keys, ideally in both positions: A - B - A and B - A - B.